ambition and insufficient oversight have led organizations to expand beyond their original mandates (Barnett and Finnemore 1999). By clearly defining the boundaries of their activities, IOs can reassure member states of their commitment to preserving sovereignty and limiting overreach.

Ultimately, such strategic retrenchment allows IOs to weather populist storms while maintaining their relevance and capacity to act. By tailoring their focus to immediate priorities and remaining adaptable, IOs can strike a balance between responsiveness to populist concerns and their broader mission of fostering international cooperation.

### *9.1.3 Preemptive Sidelining of Constituents*

IOs can proactively establish mechanisms that allow states to engage in global governance discreetly, effectively sidelining public scrutiny while fostering productive collaboration. As explored in chapter 6, populist leaders often use these private channels to engage constructively with IOs and member states, even as they publicly criticize these institutions. To ensure that skeptical leaders have avenues for meaningful yet covert participation, IOs can develop and enhance their secrecy infrastructure well in advance of a tangible threat.

Confidential participation is already an established practice within many IOs. For instance, the UN Security Council frequently holds closed-door sessions when deliberating on sensitive issues, with meeting minutes either classified or summarized in ways that obscure individual members' positions. Similarly, at the IMF, member states can openly discuss economic matters during board meetings, with their remarks sealed from public release for a period of five to seven years. The WTO adopts a comparable approach, heavily redacting documents from dispute-resolution processes to protect sensitive or proprietary information provided by member states and firms. These measures create a secure environment for candid dialogue, encouraging participation from even the most skeptical actors.

However, maintaining such confidentiality requires more than promises of discretion; it demands tangible investments in robust technologies, clear protocols, and sometimes specialized personnel. Secure communication channels, advanced encryption systems, and secure data storage solutions